



Saint Columban College
College of Computing Studies
Pagadian City



Search Source

Search source 



Medium

Web Exploitation

picoCTF 2022

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Description

The developer of this website mistakenly left an important artifact in the website source, can you find it?

Additional details will be available after launching your challenge instance.

This challenge launches an instance on demand.

Its current status is: **NOT_RUNNING**

Launch Instance

Hints 

1

38,462 users solved



53% Liked



picoCTF{FLAG}

Submit Flag

Author: The Analyst: Hyposelenia

Challenge: Search source

Category: Web Exploitation

Date: 04/14/26



I. Objective

The objective of this challenge is to find a hidden flag by inspecting the **source code of a website**.

II. Background

When you visit a website, what you see (text, images, buttons) is only the **front view**.

Behind that, there is something called **source code**, which is made using:

- HTML (structure)
- CSS (design/style)
- JavaScript (behavior)

Sometimes, developers accidentally leave **hidden information** inside these files, such as:

- comments
- unused code
- or even flags (in CTF challenges)

This challenge teaches that:

Not everything is visible on the screen — sometimes you must look behind it.

III. Tool Used

- **Web Browser** - used to open and explore the website
- **Browser Developer Tools (Inspect)** - used to view the source code
- **Ctrl + F (Find tool)** - used to quickly search for keywords like picoCTF



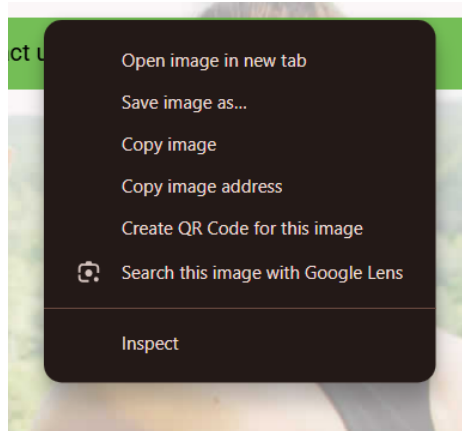
IV. Methodology

1. Launched the challenge instance and opened the website

Its current status is: **NOT_RUNNING**

Launch Instance

2. Explored the page normally to see if the flag was visible
3. Right-clicked on the page and selected **“Inspect”** to open Developer Tools



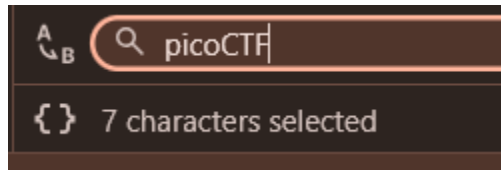
4. Looked at different files such as:

HTML

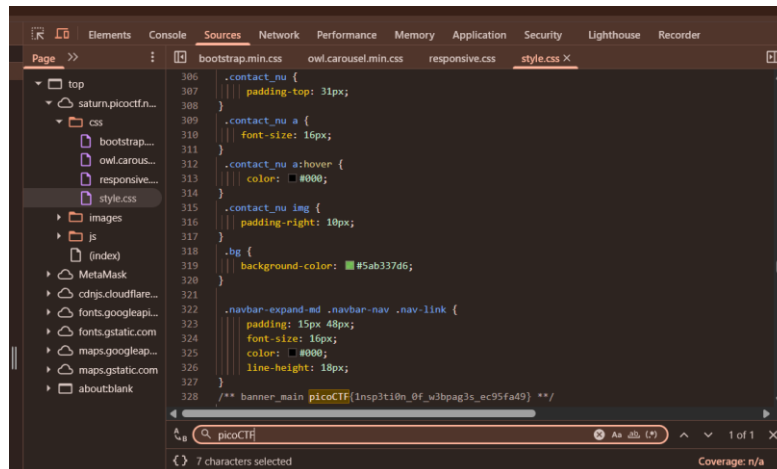
CSS

JavaScript

5. Opened each file and used **Ctrl + F**
6. Searched for the keyword **“picoCTF”**



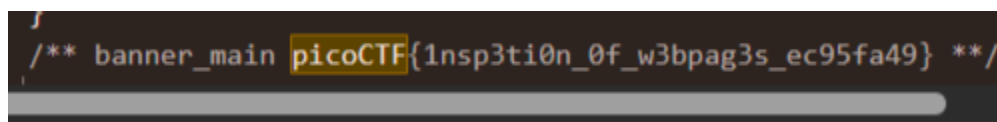
7. Found the flag inside the **style.css** file



8. Successfully retrieved the flag

V. Result

picoCTF{1nsp3ti0n_of_w3bpag3s_ec95fa49}



VI. Explanation

Think of a website like a **house**:

- What you see = the outside (paint, doors, windows)
- Source code = the inside (wires, pipes, hidden rooms)



Even if something is not visible on the screen, it might still exist in the code.

In this challenge:

- The flag was **not shown directly on the page**
- But it was **hidden inside a CSS file (style.css)**

Using **Inspect**, we were able to:

- Access all files used by the website
- Open them one by one
- Search quickly using **Ctrl + F**

Once we searched “**picoCTF**”, the flag appeared in the CSS file.

This shows that **sensitive data should never be placed in client-side code**, because anyone can view it.

VII. Conclusion

This challenge teaches an important beginner skill in web security:

- ✓ Always check the **source code**
- ✓ Use tools like **Inspect and Ctrl + F**
- ✓ Hidden information is often easy to find if you know where to look

Even simple inspection can reveal important data, making it a powerful first step in web exploitation.

— **The Analyst: Hyposelenia**